FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
March 31, 2026

Media Contact:
Andy.Orellana@tpl.org

Trust for Public Land Secures Option on Former Golden Gate Fields Site, Launching Effort in Partnership with East Bay Regional Park District to Transform 161-Acre Waterfront into Future East Bay Park

San Francisco, CA — March 31, 2026 — Trust for Public Land (TPL), working in partnership with the East Bay Regional Park District (EBRPD), today announced that it has secured an option agreement on the former Golden Gate Fields property in Albany/Berkeley, creating a once-in-a-generation opportunity to transform the 161-acre waterfront site into a future public park with community-serving recreational amenities along the San Francisco Bay, serving Bay Area residents for generations to come.

"Golden Gate Fields offers a truly generational opportunity to reimagine a world-class bayside park for the Bay Area," **said Guillermo Rodriguez, Vice President Pacific Region, California State Director.** *"With the East Bay Regional Park District and a wide range of public and community partners, we have the chance to expand shoreline access, restore vital ecosystems, and create a place where hundreds of thousands of residents can connect with the outdoors."*

The property, a former horse racing track that closed in 2024, sits along a prominent stretch of East Bay shoreline and represents one of the largest remaining opportunities to expand public access to the Bay while investing in a shoreline that is more resilient to flooding and sea level rise. TPL intends to work with partners to acquire the property and transfer it to the East Bay Regional Park District for long-term ownership and stewardship.

"*The opportunity to convert Golden Gate Fields to a fabulous shoreline park serving East Bay residents and the broader Bay Area community is a dream come true for the East Bay Regional Park District Board of Directors,"* **said Elizabeth Echols, EBRPD Board Member for Ward 1**, where the land is located. *"If the acquisition is successful, 161 acres of beautiful shoreline will forever be preserved for parkland for all to enjoy. Not only that,*

restoring the land to a more natural state will go a long way to protecting sensitive shoreline habitat not only for wildlife but also as a means to protect coastal residential communities from the impacts of our changing climate".

Golden Gate Fields has the potential to become part of a contiguous stretch of public open space and Bay shoreline, providing an incredible resource for the entire Bay Area. It would fill the remaining gap connecting existing public parks along the Bay, including Albany Beach, the 8.5-mile-long McLaughlin Eastshore State Park, 23-acre Point Isabel Regional Shoreline, 31-acre Albany Bulb, as well as the Brooks Island Regional Preserve, a 373-acre nature preserve located directly offshore.

"*The Park District has been an environmental leader for nearly 95 years and takes seriously our responsibility to steward public lands across the East Bay,"* **said Max Korten, Acting General Manager**. "*If we are successful in acquiring this property in partnership with TPL, we look forward to working with our partners at the cities of Albany and Berkeley and the public to thoughtfully balance habitat and wetland restoration with public access and recreation—creating a world-class park that is accessible to everyone."*

Additionally, this site holds the promise of providing new recreational opportunities and compatible amenities, as well as improvements to the San Francisco Bay Trail, and the deployment of nature-based solutions to protect nearby communities from the impacts of flooding and sea-level rise.

"This site offers significant potential for environmental stewardship, shoreline protection, and a variety of recreational uses and amenities," **said Peggy McQuaid, Mayor, City of Albany**. *"I look forward to the robust public engagement process and to hearing the ideas and perspectives our community members will bring to shaping this incredible space."*

"I am excited to partner with the East Bay Regional Park District to engage our community in reimagining the former racetrack as a vibrant public space, expanding opportunities to gather in community and experience the beauty of our shoreline," **said Adena Ishii, Mayor, City of Berkeley.** *"From kayaking and kite flying to sunset dining, Berkeley's waterfront parks are a treasured destination enjoyed by residents and visitors alike."*

"This is a major victory for our region. Our waterfront is one of our greatest public assets, and transforming Golden Gate Fields into a new shoreline park is an investment in the health, resilience, and future of East Bay communities," **said California State Senator Jesse Arreguín.**

"This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity for the East Bay. Transforming Golden Gate Fields from an underused site of a bygone era into a vibrant public waterfront park is exactly the kind of forward-thinking redevelopment our communities deserve - one that reflects our values, meets today's needs, and creates lasting public benefit for generations to come," **said Assemblymember Buffy Wicks.**

From Randall Preserve in Orange County to India Basin in San Francisco, Trust for Public Land has a long track record of working with communities and public agencies to protect land and create parks across California. Additional updates on the project and opportunities for public engagement will be shared as the process moves forward.

"Protecting land and creating parks at this scale takes time and deep collaboration," **continued Rodriguez.** *"We are still early in the process and will be engaging community members and stakeholders across the region in supporting acquisition of this essential missing link in an interconnected shoreline park system."*

Trust for Public Land has over 900 active or completed park projects, protecting over 540,000 acres across California and better connecting more than 1.2 million Californians to the outdoors.

East Bay Area Community Voices of Support:

"Acquiring Golden Gate Fields will add another gem to the necklace of shoreline parks that generations of Bay Area residents have worked to create for people and wildlife. We are thrilled to support this acquisition that will bring our region one step closer to the vision of Save The Bay's founders 65 years ago for everyone to have access to the Bay." ***--David Lewis, Executive Director, Save The Bay***

"The Sierra Club is thrilled with the proposed acquisition of Golden Gate Fields as public park land. It is a fantastic step forward for realizing the long-term goal of the Sierra Club to make this the keystone property of the McLaughlin Eastshore State Park." **--Norman La Force, Sierra Club State Parks Committee and 30x30 Task Force.**

"Golden Gate Fields is located in the middle of McLaughlin Eastshore State Park. Its protection will fill a missing gap in public lands and is the culmination of decades of work and advocacy. From the very creation of this 8.5-mile shoreline park, stretching from the Oakland/SF Bay Bridge up into Richmond, a major parcel has been missing – the centerpiece that has been occupied by the racetrack. Now this crucial piece can be added, thanks to the hard work and advocacy of all our partners. This crowning achievement is a major milestone for our shoreline." **--Robert Cheasty, Executive Director, Citizens for East Shore Parks**

"This is a rare opportunity to restore living shoreline along the East Bay—creating habitat for threatened birds, improving coastal resilience for nearby communities, and advancing a continuous Bayshore park from the Bay Bridge to Richmond."
--Glenn Phillips, Executive Director of the Golden Gate Bird Alliance.

“We know that conserving and restoring habitats along our shorelines is one of the most important paths to climate resilience, protecting wildlife and communities. Restoration of these historic tidal wetlands will provide vital habitat for vulnerable species in San Francisco Bay, especially birds that rely on tidal marshes and mudflats, like Western Sandpipers and Black-necked Stilts. It will also give East Bay residents new opportunities to get out and enjoy the natural wonder of our beautiful bay." --**Casey Skinner, Audubon California's San Francisco Bay Program Director.**

"The transformation of Golden Gate Fields is a once-in-a-generation opportunity to create a world-class waterfront that belongs to everyone. As the representative for the Berkeley portion of this area, I am thrilled to support an effort that expands public access to our shoreline, ensuring it becomes a vibrant, inclusive amenity for Berkeley residents of all ages and abilities to enjoy for decades to come."
--Berkeley City Councilmember Rashi Kesarwani

###

About East Bay Regional Park District
Established in 1934, the East Bay Regional Park District is a public agency that manages an extensive system of parks, trails, and open space across Alameda and Contra Costa counties in California. It is led by an elected Board of Directors representing 7 Wards including Elizabeth Echols (Ward 1), Lynda Deschambault (Ward 2), Dennis Waespi (Ward 3), Luana España (Ward 4), Olivia Sanwong (Ward 5), John Mercurio (Ward 6) and Colin Coffey (Ward 7). The Park District provides recreational opportunities such as hiking, biking, camping, fishing, and swimming, while conserving wildlife habitats and natural resources. The Park District plays a vital role in environmental stewardship, public education, and ensuring access to nature for millions of residents and visitors each year. The Park District is primarily supported by local property taxes and grant funding.

About Trust for Public Land
Trust for Public Land (TPL) is a national nonprofit that works to connect everyone to the benefits and joys of the outdoors. As a leader in equitable access to the outdoors, TPL works with communities to create parks and protect public land where they are needed most. Since 1972, TPL has protected more than 4 million acres of public land, created more than 5,500 parks, trails, schoolyards, and iconic outdoor places, raised $112 billion in public funding for parks and public lands, and connected nearly 10 million people to the outdoors. To learn more, visit www.tpl.org